

Democrats remain committed to finding a realistic, bipartisan agreement on securing the southern border. We will not accept Donald Trump's cruel border policies as envisioned in H.R. 2, which even Speaker JOHNSON has reminded his colleagues didn't get a single Democratic vote in the Senate. But if Republicans show they are serious about meeting us in the middle, we are willing to meet them in the middle.

I hope my Republican colleagues take to heart President Zelenskyy's warnings: The one person happy right now about the gridlock in Congress is Vladimir Putin. He is delighting in the fact that Donald Trump's border policies are sabotaging military aid to Ukraine.

I urge my Republican colleagues to show they are serious about getting a supplemental package done. Democrats are still trying, and we will continue to work with Republicans in good faith in the coming days.

NATIONAL DEFENSE AUTHORIZATION ACT

Mr. President, now, on the NDAA, the Senate will move forward on the annual Defense Authorization Act, moving us closer to passing this bill for the 62nd year in a row.

Both sides have done terrific work these past few months getting the NDAA over the finish line. The Senate passed our version of the NDAA with a strong 86-to-11 vote back in July. That is a good bipartisan vote, majorities of both parties supporting it. And over the past few weeks, conferees have done commendable work reconciling the Senate and House version. And I am pleased that the conference has reported a strong defense bill that contains many of the policies the Senate passed back in July.

We are making major strides to outcompete the Chinese Government by approving President Biden's trilateral U.S., U.K., and Australia nuclear submarine agreement. This historic agreement will create a new fleet of nuclear-powered submarines to counter the Chinese Communist Party's influence in the Pacific. And AUKUS, in general, will be a critical part of ensuring stability in that region. We have worked all year long to get it passed through Congress, and I applaud my colleagues on both sides for their efforts.

As I have said repeatedly, we began the month of December with three major goals here in the Senate before the end of the year: First, we had to end the unprecedented monthslong and destructive blockade of hundreds of military nominees. We have done that. Second, we needed to pass the NDAA as we have for decades on a bipartisan basis. We are on track to do that this week. And, finally, most difficult of all, we must reach an agreement with Republicans on the national security supplemental.

Democrats' attitude on the supplemental can be boiled down two words: We are "still trying." We want to get something done. We hope our Repub-

lican colleagues are serious—serious—about getting something done too.

INFLATION REDUCTION ACT

Mr. President, on the Inflation Reduction Act accomplishments, this morning, the American people received more proof that the Biden and Democratic agenda is working.

The Labor Department reported today that year-over-year inflation in November slowed down to 3.1 percent. At the beginning of this year, it was more than double, at 6.4 percent.

And remember, last summer, before we passed the Inflation Reduction Act and the CHIPS and Science Act, inflation was over 9 percent—from 9 percent all the way down to 3.1 percent. We have made big progress. Meanwhile, the labor market remains strong. Jobs are up, higher than they were before the pandemic. And listen to this: Investment in manufacturing construction—manufacturing construction, plants that will turn out goods that we can consume here and export—is at a 20-year high, more than double its highest under the previous administration.

There is a lot of talk from the previous President about jobs. He did very little. This administration, with what we have done, is really producing jobs, jobs, jobs.

No one should be surprised. Thanks to the Democratic work on the IRA, 2023 has been a banner year for American job creation and for American manufacturing; at the same time, getting inflation and the costs to American families down.

In 2023, dozens of companies have announced new investments in the United States, resulting in hundreds of green new clean energy projects and creating tens of thousands of new, good-paying jobs.

And that is just 2023. The Inflation Reduction Act is projected to create another 1.5 million jobs over the next decade.

According to the White House, private companies have announced more than 600 billion in investments across the country, many spurred by the IRA—the Inflation Reduction Act.

And it is not just through manufacturing that the Democratic agenda is paying dividends. In a few short weeks, seniors, for the first time, will have a cap on how much they pay for prescription drugs, thanks to the Inflation Reduction Act.

This is life-changing news for seniors across the country. Never again will a horrible diagnosis mean \$10,000 or more to get the drug you need to survive. Thanks to the Inflation Reduction Act, insulin is also capped at \$35 a month for seniors on Medicaid, and vaccines are now free.

Let me repeat that. Vaccines are free, improving healthcare across America and helping people be healthy without having to pay for it, in terms of things they can't afford.

Drugmakers are penalized if they raise prices faster than inflation. The

administration is negotiating right now for better prices for 10 of the highest cost, most commonly used drugs in Medicare.

And because ACA premiums are becoming more affordable, this year we are seeing a record number of Americans sign up for healthcare on the individual marketplaces.

It takes a lot of work, but the Democrats' agenda is paying off. Costs are coming down. Jobs and opportunities are going up. And while there is a lot of work to do, the American economy is on the right track.

I yield the floor.

I suggest the absence of a quorum.

The ACTING PRESIDENT pro tempore. The clerk will call the roll.

The senior assistant legislative clerk proceeded to call the roll.

Mr. MCCONNELL. Mr. President, I ask unanimous consent that the order for the quorum call be rescinded.

The PRESIDING OFFICER. (Mr. PADILLA). Without objection, it is so ordered.

RECOGNITION OF THE MINORITY LEADER

The Republican leader is recognized.

UKRAINE

Mr. MCCONNELL. Mr. President, this morning, the Senate welcomed Ukraine's inspirational and determined President Zelenskyy to the Capitol.

For nearly 2 years, the people of Ukraine have defied the world's expectations. They have ground down the world's second most powerful military, and they have confounded Putin's aggressive, imperialist aspirations. At every step of the way, America's commitment and support has provided critical fuel for Ukraine's resistance and helped European allies wake up from a holiday from history.

Now, our allies are awake. They are investing in collective defense, and clear majorities of Americans understand the importance of America's continuing to lead as the arsenal of democracy.

I have been a staunch supporter of Ukraine's fight to take back its land, liberate its people, and restore its sovereignty since the beginning of Russia's invasion way back in 2014. Our Ukrainian friends' cause is just, and if the West continues to stand with them, they can win.

But let's be absolutely clear: Ukraine's cause hasn't always been popular here in Washington.

In 2021, Republicans recommended that the Biden administration step up assistance to help Ukraine deter renewed Russian threats, and the administration seemed to think Ukraine was a frozen conflict and a distraction from other priorities. In early 2022, as the gravity of Putin's plans came into focus, Republicans urged the President to expedite shipments of critical weapons systems to stop Russia's advance, but his administration's unfounded fear of escalating the conflict repeatedly kept decisive capabilities out of Ukrainian hands at critical moments.

When Russian troops crossed the border and the administration first came